



Cultural Differences

"老外" Is Not Rude:

Understanding Chinese

Nicknames and Terms for

CDISCOVERY
Foreigners

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"老外" Is Not Rude: Understanding Chinese

Nicknames and Terms for Foreigners



One of the first things foreigners in China notice is being called "老外" (lǎowài). Some newcomers feel offended, thinking it means "old foreigner" or is somehow disrespectful.

In reality, it's one of the most common and generally neutral-to-friendly terms Chinese people use for foreigners. To understand why, you need to understand how the Chinese prefix "老" (lǎo -- "old") works in names.

The "老 + Surname" Convention: A Sign of Familiarity

In Chinese, adding "老" (lǎo) before someone's surname is a common, affectionate way to address friends, colleagues, and acquaintances. It signals familiarity and warmth --

NOT that the person is old:



* 老王 (Lǎo Wáng) -- "Old Wang" = a friendly way to refer to someone named Wang

* 老李 (Lǎo Lǐ) -- "Old Li" = same, for someone named Li

* 老张 (Lǎo Zhāng) -- "Old Zhang" = same, for someone named Zhang

* 老刘 (Lǎo Liú) -- "Old Liu" = same, for someone named Liu

This is used for people of ALL ages -- a 25-year-old named Wang can be called 老王 by friends and colleagues. It's equivalent to saying "mate" in British English or "dude" in American English. Nobody is commenting on age.

So What Does "老外" Actually Mean?

"老外" follows the same pattern -- "老" (lǎo) + "外" (wài, short for 外国人 wàiguó rén, "foreigner"). It literally means something like "the foreigner" in a casual, familiar way.

It's the same linguistic pattern as 老王, 老李, etc.

The term became popular in the 1980s-90s as China opened up and more foreigners



visited. It's roughly equivalent to:

- * "Expat" in English (neutral descriptor)

- * "Gaijin" (外人) in Japanese (though gaijin can carry more nuance)

- * "Gringo" in Latin American Spanish (can be neutral or slightly teasing, depending on context)

Tone Matters: When Is It Friendly vs. Slightly Rude?

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- * Friendly/Neutral:

- * "那个老外中文说得真好！" (That foreigner's Chinese is really good!) -- This is a compliment.

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- * Friendly/Neutral:

- * "你是老外吧？" (You're a foreigner, right?) -- Just a casual observation.



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* Possibly dismissive:

* "老外不懂的" (Foreigners don't understand this) -- Can be slightly condescending, but usually not hostile.

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* Rarely rude:

* Shouted at someone aggressively -- but this is extremely uncommon.

Other Terms for Foreigners You Might Hear

* 外国人 (wàiguórén) -- "Foreign person." Formal, neutral, used in official contexts.

* 外籍人士 (wàijí rénshì) -- "Foreign national." Very formal, used in legal/official documents.

* 洋人 (yáng rén) -- "Ocean person." Older term from the colonial era. Rarely used today, can sound old-fashioned.



* 歪果仁 (wāiguǒrén) -- Internet slang/meme pronunciation of 外国人. Playful, not offensive.

* 国际友人 (guójì yǒurén) -- "International friend." Used in formal/political contexts. Very polite.

The Flip Side: Chinese Nicknames for Each Other

Chinese people use nickname prefixes for everyone, not just foreigners:

* 小 + surname (xiǎo -- "little"): 小王, 小李 -- for younger people or juniors

* 老 + surname (lǎo -- "old"): 老王, 老李 -- for peers or slightly older people

* 大 + surname (dà -- "big"): 大刘, 大张 -- for someone who's tall or older

* 阿 + surname (ā): 阿明, 阿花 -- common in southern China, very affectionate

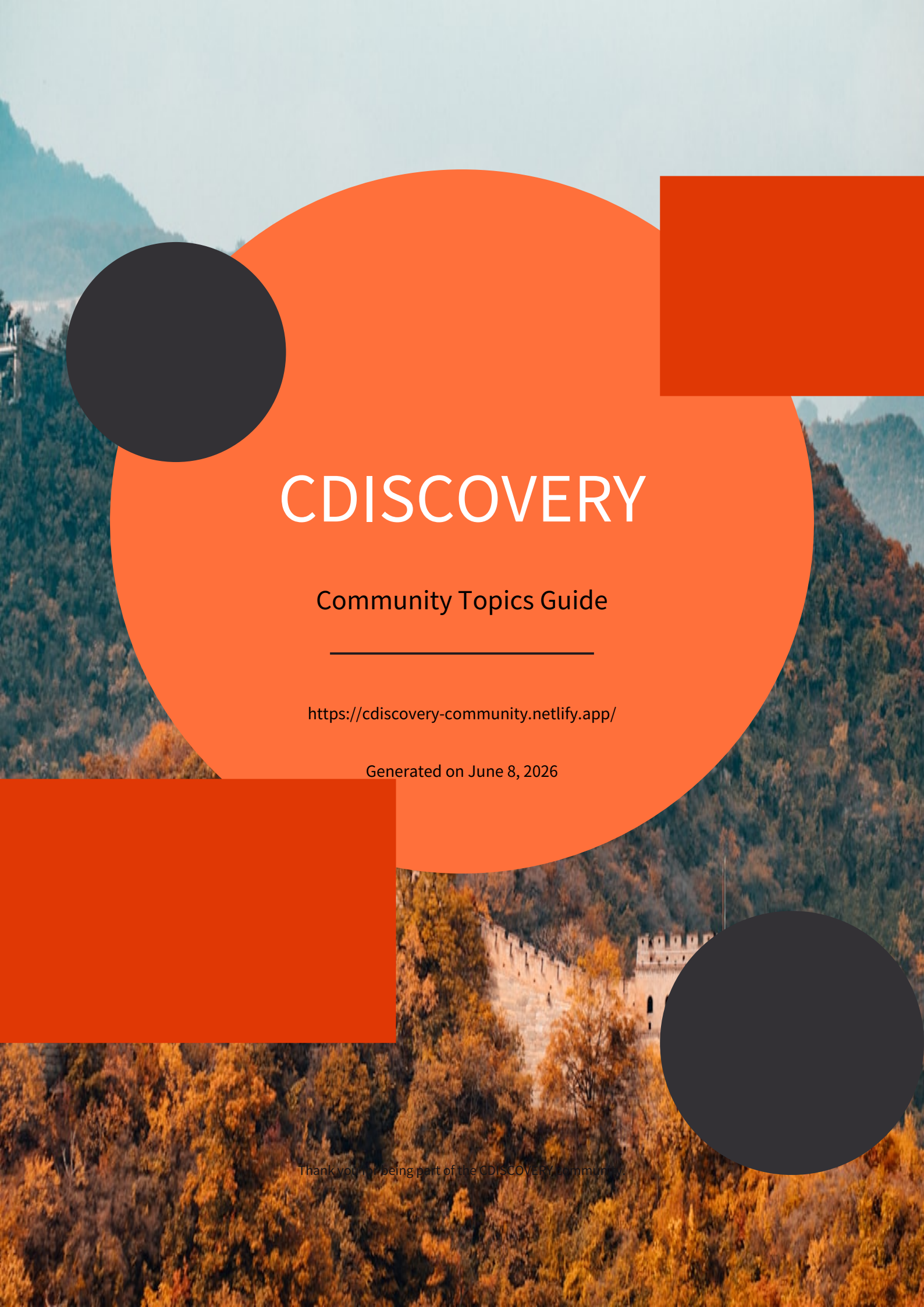
Bottom Line



If someone calls you "老外," smile -- they're treating you like a familiar presence in their community, not insulting you. If it bothers you, you can gently say "叫我[你的名字]就好" (jiào wǒ [name] jiù hǎo -- "Just call me [name]") and most people will happily switch.

Sources: Sources: 百度百科 --

老外 • 教育部语言文字应用研究所

The background of the cover is a scenic photograph of the Great Wall of China winding through a forest with autumn-colored trees. Overlaid on this are several geometric shapes: a large orange circle in the center, a smaller dark grey circle in the top left, a solid orange rectangle in the top right, a solid orange rectangle in the bottom left, and another dark grey circle in the bottom right.

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Thank you for being part of the CDISCOVERY community!